

Shakespearean Sonnets

Anony Mouse

William Shakespeare was the author of many plays, including tragedies like *Romeo and Juliet*, comedies like *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, and histories like *Richard II*. Or was he?

There is ample controversy as to whether Shakespeare himself wrote these works, or if he served as the stand-in for another author such as Christopher Marlowe or Francis Bacon. We will likely never know who the true author of Shakespeare's works was, but "William Shakespeare," whoever he *actually* was, also wrote a series of sonnets. One of the most famous of these is Sonnet 18:

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate:
Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
And summer's lease hath all too short a date;
Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines,
And often is his gold complexion dimm'd;
And every fair from fair sometime declines,
By chance or nature's changing course untrimm'd;
But thy eternal summer shall not fade,
Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st;
Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,
When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st:
So long as men can breathe or eyes can see,
So long lives this, and this gives life to thee.

As you can see from this example, Shakespearean sonnets consist of 14 lines of iambic pentameter. They typically have three quatrains followed by a couplet, following the rhyme scheme **ABAB CDCD EFEF GG**.

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